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QUALITATIVE ELECTION STUDY OF BRITAIN

UWE Bristol | University of the West of England

Building a human-centered Large Language Model dataset from longitudinal QESB (2010 to 2024) data.

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What's Wrong with Today's LLMs?

- The people who train LLMs aren't using people like ours
- LLMs mostly trained on
  - books, news articles, Wiki entries, academic pubs, writing in polished, professional styles
  - valuable for modeling formal language, understanding discourses
  - only elite perspectives
  - not representative of how ordinary people speak or reason

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What's Wrong with Today's LLMs?

- Or LLMs are trained on
  - large volumes of user-generated text from online platforms such as Reddit, Stack Exchange, and similar forums
  - expands the range of linguistic styles, but
  - often anonymous or pseudonymous, and little is known about their demographic or political characteristics
  - Are they voters? We don't know.

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What's Wrong with Today's LLMs?

- Ethical concerns
  - trained on vast quantities of unlicensed content such as copyrighted books and articles scraped from the web without permission
  - raises legal challenges and ethical concerns about intellectual property and author consent
  - data taken from social media or online forums, they are often collected without informed consent
  - questions about data ownership, representation, and the potential exploitation of communities whose speech may be used to train commercial systems without compensation or oversight

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What Makes the QESB Special?

- Imagine if the BES panel could talk back — that's what QESB does
- Longitudinal interviews, same people, same questions, across 5 elections and 2 referendums

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We Did Something New

- We turned our rich transcripts into a training set for AI
- Interview → cleaned → structured for machine learning
- AI trained by political scientists (with help from clever computer scientists!)

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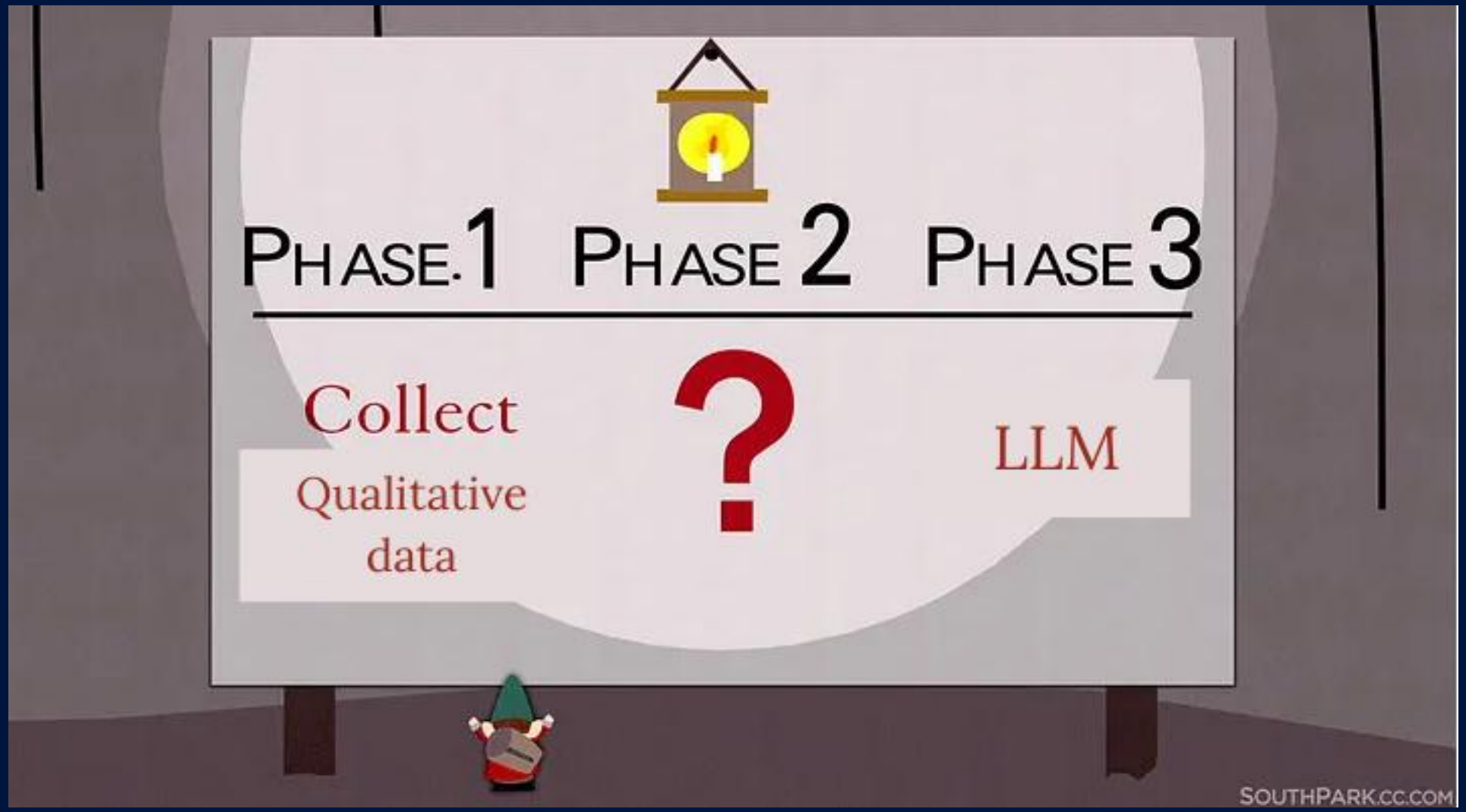
The nerdy stuff



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The nerdy stuff

1. Standardize formatting in .docx files across several years
2. Transform .docx into markdown
3. Use regular expressions to extract information from markdown
4. Save information in JSON format (JavaScript Object Notation). Regular Expressions can be used to match patterns in text (e.g. emails, phone numbers, urls, but also general text formatting (bold text))
5. JSON is a standard format that saves information as {Key : Value} (e.g., {"Name" : "Barack Obama"})

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Your Voting Story

I: With that we'll move into the substantive questions and I'll leave you with that to think about. So we're covering kind of two parts first of all, one's your kind of voting day story. If anyone's done the election study before they will remember this bit, where we want to really hear about, you know, what time you woke up on election day, what time did you vote, did you get any literature on election day, those kind of things? Did you vote how you thought you were going to vote, how did you feel when you voted, and did it feel any different? So if I start with Charlotte, what was your voting day like?

Charlotte: So I took the day off. I took the day off and the day after, so I had a nice leisurely day. We went out to vote. I went out with my husband about, I'm going to say about nine, quarter past nine. I had a whole outfit, I had a hat, it was a whole thing. The voting station, I can't remember the right word, is round the corner from my house, which is a nice quiet walk. It felt a bit weird having to show my ID. I don't enjoy that. I stood and read down the ballot paper. I observed the fact that, in my constituency, we had some morn YouTuber who'd managed to get people to put him on the ballot in lots of constituencies. I really hope he gets done for that. I observed the Reform candidate and went hmm! {pr: look of disgust} I was sad there was no Green candidate, and in the end I voted SNP, pretty much like I usually do! {pr: laughs} We took some post-voting selfies and put them on Instagram to encourage people to vote. Then my husband went and did the shopping and I went and sat in my house and did the housework so that we could prepare, and then the rest of the day it was mostly napping because I stayed up all night. And then I snacked and then I napped some more and I got up about quarter to ten and that was me until eight in the morning, half eight the next day.

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Building the QESB LLM

- Pipeline choices (Python tooling; controlled vocabulary; standardised metadata). Tokenisation and data conversion (≈ 1.5 M tokens).
- Training vs. fine-tuning splits
- Evaluation: language quality plus domain benchmarks (classification, topic coherence).
- Versioning & reproducibility (code on MethodsHub; UK Data Service archiving).

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What Can You Do With It?

- Answering old questions in new ways to expand political science research
- Use cases:
  - predict political leaning,
  - track issue salience,
  - classify stance on Brexit

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Why It's Ethical AI

- No scraping. No guessing. Just voters who agreed to be heard
- Consent, transparency, traceability (unlike most LLM datasets)

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How Political Scientists Can Use It

- You don’t need to code, you just need questions
- Analyze discourse, train models, co-author new methods papers

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Let's Build This Together

- Backwards looking questions for the longitudinal dataset
- Use the data on your own (when it is released) or contact us about collaborations

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An invitation to collarborate

- Ideas to take this forward into GE 2029 (?) and collaborations
- Using our templates and workflow if you have qual data to convert